

Session 25: Repeated Words Between Juxtaposed Literary Units

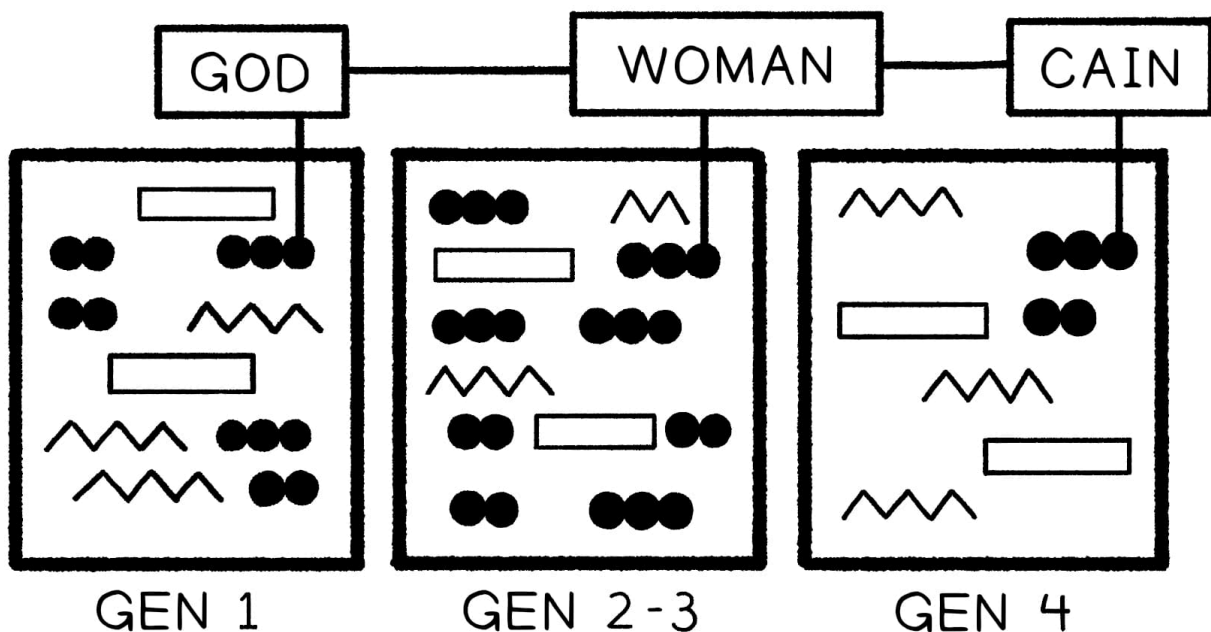
Key Takeaways

- The relationships between connected literary units can work in different ways (e.g., contrast, create a sequence), but at the core is an analogy.
- The reader is being asked to read a particular literary unit on analogy with another literary unit in order to discover a deeper meaning.
- Sometimes entire stories or scenes are designed to repeat elements of other stories. This involves not only repeated words but parallel narrative patterns, themes, and sequences.
- Sometimes the narratives to be compared are next to each other, like in Genesis 2-3 and Genesis 4. In these narratives, we watch Human and Life set a template for redefining “good” and “bad” on their own terms, which is replayed by the next generation.

Narrative Analogy Between Literary Units

Narrative analogy is “[w]hen two or more characters, stories, scenes, or other aspects of a biblical text bear a significant amount of resemblance to one another, inviting further comparison between the two. The comparison sheds new light on both aspects of the text, highlighting parallels, foreshadowing, reversal, progression, or various other effects generated by their mutual resemblance and difference. Through this device, to quote Robert Alter, ‘one part of the text provides oblique commentary on another.’”

Sigmon, Brian (2013). [*Between Eden and Egypt: Echoes of the Garden Narrative in the Story of Joseph and His Brothers*](#). Doctoral Dissertation, Marquette University. 46.



Repeated Words Linking Different Literary Units. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

"Good" in Genesis 1-3

- Genesis 1:4: "And God saw that the light was good (וִירָא ... כִּי טוֹב)."
- Genesis 1:10: "And God saw that [the dry land] was good (וִירָא ... כִּי טוֹב)."
- Genesis 1:12: "And God saw that [the vegetation] was good (וִירָא ... כִּי טוֹב)."
- Genesis 1:18: "And God saw that [the lights] was good (וִירָא ... כִּי טוֹב)."
- Genesis 1:21: "And God saw that [the sea life] was good (וִירָא ... כִּי טוֹב)."
- Genesis 1:25: "And God saw that [the land life] was good (וִירָא ... כִּי טוֹב)."
- Genesis 1:31: "And God saw all that he had made, and look, it was very good (וִירָא ... וַהֲנֵה טוֹב מְאֹד)."

In terms of God's character portrait, this repetition makes a clear claim: God is the provider and evaluator of what is truly good. In Genesis 1, "good" defines both the ordered environments that make life possible (days one through three) and the abundant creatures that fill the skies and the land (days four through six).

In the next literary unit, the Eden narrative (Gen. 2:4-3:24), we find this same vocabulary continued, but in new and creative ways.

Genesis 2:9 Instructor's Translation

And Yahweh God caused the growth of every tree that was desirable to see, and good for eating, and the tree of life was in the middle of the garden and the tree of knowing of good and bad.

Genesis 1 taught us that God is the provider, evaluator, and ultimate “knower” of what is good, and we know that he has appointed humans to rule the world on his behalf as his divine image. The humans have a choice before them, symbolized by two trees: one represents life (which is good), and the other represents knowing good and bad. Will the humans allow God to be the prime “knower” of what is good and not-good, or will they take this knowledge for themselves?

Genesis 2:18 Instructor's Translation

Then Yahweh God said, “It is not good for the human to be alone ...”

Once again, God is the evaluator of what is good and not good (as in Gen. 1), and once again he provides what is good for the human: a partner without whom he cannot accomplish the image of God mission given in Genesis 1:26-28.

Summary of "Good" in Genesis 1 and 2

Genesis 1:1-2:3 Instructor's Translation

¹⁰ “... and God saw that it was good.”

¹² “... and God saw that it was good.”

¹⁸ “... and God saw that it was good.”

³¹ “... and God saw that it was very good.”

Genesis 2:17-18 Instructor's Translation

¹⁷ from the tree of knowing good and bad you shall not eat ...

¹⁸ ... it is not good for the human to be alone;”

"Good" in Genesis 3

3:1-5	Theme: dialogue about God's command concerning the fruit Characters: snake, woman (active) Setting: inside the garden Snake: “ Did God really say you may not eat from any tree in the garden?” Woman: “From the fruit of the tree in the middle of the garden God said, ‘ You shall not eat from it ...”	
	3:6-7	Theme: the woman and man eat the fruit and are changed Characters: the woman and the husband Setting: the center of the garden A And the woman saw that the tree was good for eating B and desirable to the eyes and desirable for becoming wise
“Good” in Genesis 3. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).		

		C and she took from its fruit and she ate C' and she gave also to her husband and he ate . B' And the eyes of the two of them were opened and they knew they were naked A' and they sewed the leaves of a fig tree and made garments.
3:8-13	Theme: dialogue about the eating of the fruit Characters: Yahweh, <i>ha'adam</i>, the woman Setting: inside the garden	
	Yahweh: “ Did you eat from the tree which I commanded you not to eat from it? ” Woman: “The snake deceived me, and I ate from it.”	
<i>“Good” in Genesis 3. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).</i>		

This story is the ultimate tragedy because the snake presents itself as one with superior knowledge about God’s knowledge. He contradicts God’s wisdom, saying that taking the knowing of good and bad will not lead to death but to greater wisdom.

The key phrase “and the woman saw ... good” is precisely the same phrase that was repeated seven times in Genesis 1. Eve is portrayed as one who usurps the role and prerogative of God. Note that what God saw as good, he "gave," whereas what the woman saw as good, she "took."

Lead Words and Analogies Between Genesis 3 and 4

The profile of Adam and Eve’s actions in Genesis 3 is a template for the next generation, who replays the failure of their parents. The failure of Cain in Genesis 4 is deliberately set on analogy to the story of Genesis 3 and uses all of its key vocabulary.

Analogy	Genesis 2-3: Adam and Eve	Genesis 4: Cain and Abel
Human given a significant choice about “good”	2:16-17: “From any tree of the garden you may eat, but from the tree of knowing good and evil you should not eat, because the day you eat from it you will surely die.”	4:5-7: But Yahweh did not regard Cain’s offering, and Cain was very angry ... Yahweh said “Why are you angry, and why has your face fallen? Isn’t it the case that if you do good , you will be lifted up?”
<i>Lead Words Through Genesis 3 and 4. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).</i>		

Analogy	Genesis 2-3: Adam and Eve	Genesis 4: Cain and Abel
Human tempted by an “animal”	3:1: Now the snake was more crafty than any creature of the field ... and he said to the woman, “Did God really say not to eat from any tree in the garden?”	4:7: “But if you don’t do good , sin is a croucher at the door , and it’s desire is for you.”
Human gives into temptation with destructive consequences	3:6: When the woman saw that the tree was good for food, and desirable to the eyes, and desirable for gaining wisdom ... she took	4:5: And Cain was very angry 4:8 And Cain spoke to Abel his brother and while they were in the field Cain rose up against Abel his brother and murdered him.
God shows up to ask a leading question	3:9: And God called out to the human, and said, “ Where are you (איכה) ?” 3:13: And God said to the woman, “ What have you done? ” (מה עשית)	4:9: And God said to Cain, “ Where is your (אי) brother Abel? ” 4:10 And God said, “ What have you done? ” (מה עשית)
Human dodges the question	3:12: The human said, “The woman who you set with me, she gave to me and I ate.”	4:9: “I don’t know! Am I my brother’s keeper?”
The perpetrator is cursed	3:14: God said to the serpent, “Because you have done this, you are cursed from every beast and from every creature of the field.”	4:11: “And now you are cursed from the ground”
Inverted desire	3:16: “Your desire will be toward your husband, and he will rule over you.”	4:7: “Sin ... its desire is toward you, and you will rule it.”
Working the ground will now be more difficult	3:17b: “in pain you will eat from the ground ” 3:23: And God sent him from the garden of Eden to work the ground	4:12: “For you will work the ground , and it will no longer give its strength to you.”
The human is banished from the divine presence	3:23-24: And [God] banished the human and he camped east of the garden of Eden	4:14: “Behold, you have banished me from the face of the ground and from your presence.” 4:16 And Cain settled in the land of Nod, east of Eden .

Lead Words Through Genesis 3 and 4. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

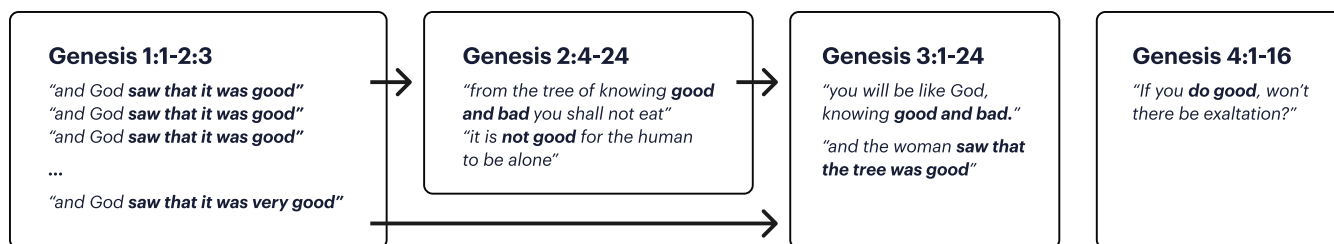
Notice that in each parallel element, the reader is invited to make comparisons and contrasts between the two stories that offer insight into Cain's character.

In both stories, the "tester" is presented as an animal—it's a snake in Genesis 3, and in Genesis 4 "sin" is animated as a "croucher," an animal-like reality that wants to take the lives of others for its own.

Genesis 3 and 4 "were purposely juxtaposed for the effect they would have early on in the sequence of primeval episodes from Eden to the Tower of Babel ... The first human is probed within the garden, while Cain is tested outside the garden. The first test is that of the first human who is warned not to eat ... lest he die. The second test is that of his son Cain who is admonished to rule over sin, so that his brother doesn't die ... The first tester is a mysterious snake, the second is an animated character called 'sin.' While the man and woman share responsibility ... Cain alone is guilty for his crime."

German, Igal (2016). [*The Fall Reconsidered: A Literary Synthesis of the Primeval Sin Narratives*](#). Pickwick Publications. 4.

Summary of "Good" in Genesis 1-4



Summary of "Good" in Genesis 1-4. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

- Genesis 1:1-2:3: God sees what is good and gives it freely.
- Genesis 2:4-24: Knowing good and bad is dangerous for humans. God also knows what is not good, and he provides good instead.
- Genesis 3:1-24: Humans who want god-like knowledge of good and not good quickly end up ashamed and guilty ...
- Genesis 4:1-17: ... and dead.

Reflection Question

We talked about the repeated word "good" a few sessions ago as well. Summarize what you've learned about how the author uses the word "good" to set up the story of the Bible.